

Features

Power2Go claims support for Blu-Ray, as does Nero. But here, the support is more prominent: the interface sports three tabs—CD, DVD, and Blu-ray! It also supports creation of WMA music CDs and DVDs in addition to MP3 and WAV (the latter not on DVD), a feature not common to the other applications, except Easy Media Creator. As for the other necessary features, they're all there. The only notable package that comes bundled is the audio ripping tool.

Ease Of Use

We thought CyberLink would extend their typical PowerDVD skinning to Power2Go—that, thankfully, is not the case! CyberLink has adopted a simple design, which reduces the load on system memory.

The various burning formats such as data, audio and video were well sorted, and a newbie can use this software with ease. There's a neat 'Utilities' section that features disc image burning, audio ripping, and the audio converter. However, it does not provide configuration options—such as setting the drive's write speed and allowing multi-session—when burning a disc image.

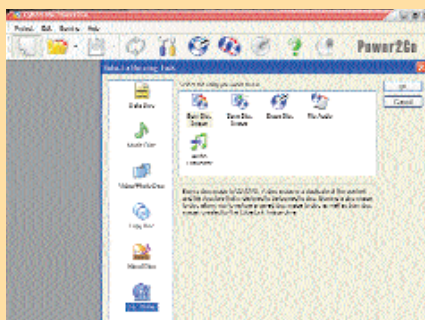


Image burning and Audio Ripping tools in CyberLink are located under Disc utilities

Performance

Power2Go does not tax the system like Nero does. The memory usage and CPU usage were surprisingly moderate, allowing a user to run other applications such as a movie player while burning media. Along with Disc Master 2, Power2Go was the best when it came to the time taken to burn a CD with 690 MB of data.

Site: www.cyberlink.com/multi/products/main_24_ENU.html

InterVideo Disc Master 2

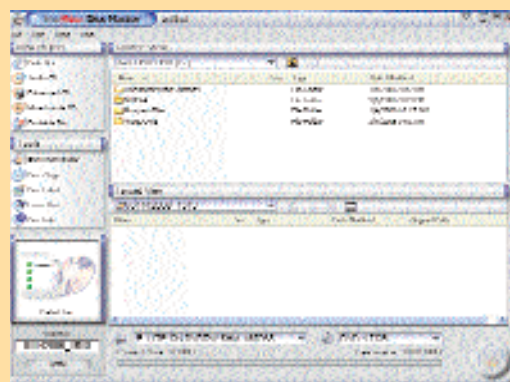
InterVideo's Disc Master 2 is a very mediocre application with respect to the interface and content. As a saving grace, it doesn't burden the system too much.

Features

This application lacks the ability to create video discs and MP3 DVDs, which we believe is a mandatory feature for burning software. Creation of a disc image is also not possible; Disc Master 2 is the only application in this comparison that didn't feature this tool. On the brighter side, it has many necessary features, such as image burning, creation of bootable CDs and DVDs, and dual-layer support. It also supported multi-session and overburning.

Ease Of Use

A straightforward interface lists all the necessary tasks related to burning on the left pane. The right half is the drag-and-drop interface,



Disc Master sports a very simple and easy to use interface that anybody can understand

How We Tested

The Test Machine

The PC on which we tested the CD/DVD burning software was powered by an AMD 64 3000+ (socket 754) on an MSI K8T Neo motherboard with 1 GB of Corsair DDR 400 RAM.

The operating system we used was Windows XP (32-bit) with Service Pack 2. Anti-virus software (Norton AntiVirus 2005) was also installed to give the test machine a realistic environment—that of a regular personal computer. The LiteOn Super AllWrite DVD-Writer (model SHM-165P6S) was used as the media writing device.

Other hardware included an nVidia GeForce FX 5950 (256 MB) card and a Seagate Barracuda hard disk.

We tested the Linux-based software on custom-installed Fedora Core 3 using the same machine as above. No anti-virus software was installed on the Linux machine.

Both software—K3b and NeroLinux—operated in the GNOME environment of Fedora. The test machine was made to dual boot Windows XP and Fedora Core 3.

Features

We separated disc burning-related features from additional utilities such as media players. This ensured that priority was given to the purpose for which the software is implemented. A higher weightage was given to features than additional packages.

Of course, a software that had extra utilities in addition to exceptional recording/burning features would win over the rest.

Ease Of Use

Ease of use is one of the most important criteria when considering burning software, and considerable consideration was given to this aspect. The installation of Windows-based software was easy in all cases, and one cannot really differentiate between software based on the installation Wizards.

The story is quite different when installing Linux-based software. The installation patterns of the Linux software were different from each other. Software that installed from package managers such as RPM and DPKG was scored over those that installed from a tarball (.tar.gz, .tar.bz2). Other parameters considered were the user interface, Wizards for burning etc., and the file browser.

Performance

For Windows-based software, the page file usage was considered as memory consumption, while Fedora indicated RAM and swap file usage separately.

The idle state in both cases is the record of the memory consumed when no application is running (except for the normal process and services running on an operating system). The CD/DVD burning application was made to run with Task Manager (Windows XP) or System Monitor (Fedora Core 3) in the backdrop. The peak memory usage during the recording/burning was record as the burn state consumption. The difference in the value of the two states gives (approximately) the memory consumed by the CD/DVD burning application.

The time taken to burn a 690 MB data CD and a 550 MB disc image (ISO) were also noted as performance parameters.